

The Promise

THE PROMISE

A Name to Grow Into

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The Promise: A Name to Grow Into

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*For the man who picked me —
and for everyone still sitting down,
showing up,
and staying.*

THE DAY YOU PICKED ME

Some kids come to their fathers
the ordinary way.

I didn't.

You looked at me,
and you picked me.

On purpose.



THE NAME

You gave me your name.

It was too big for me then,
like your coat.

"Don't worry," you said.
"It's a name to grow into."



You didn't teach me with speeches.

You taught me by being there.

Again.

And again.

And again.



WHAT STAYING LOOKS LIKE

Sitting in the bleachers.

Sitting in the waiting room.

Sitting on the edge of my bed
on the nights I couldn't say why I was sad.

You never fixed it from the doorway.

You always came in
and sat down.



THE HARD YEARS

I got lost for a while.
Most people would have stopped looking.

You didn't.

You came and got me.
Like the first time.

On purpose.



GROWN

One day the coat fit.

One day the name fit, too.

And I understood
that you hadn't just given me a name.

You'd shown me what to do with it.



THE WORK I DO NOW

Years later,
I sit beside people
who are saying goodbye.

Families.
Grandfathers.
Mothers.

People who are scared.

I stay.

Because you taught me how.

THE WORK I DO NOW

Years later,
I sit beside people
who are saying
goodbye.

Families.
Grandfathers.
Mothers.

People who
are scared.

I stay.

Because you
taught me how.



THE PROMISE

You picked me once.

Now I spend my life
picking others.

Sitting down.

Showing up.

Staying.

The promise
is still being kept.

THE PROMISE

You picked me once.

Now I spend my life
picking others.

Sitting down.

Showing up.

Staying.

The promise
is still being kept.



A NAME TO GROW INTO

Someday, somebody small
might get my name.

It'll be too big for them at first.

That's all right.

I know exactly
what to tell them.



THE RED BIRD

On the day you drove me home,
a red bird sat outside the car window.

You said it meant
somebody who loved me was near.

You were right.

It was you.

